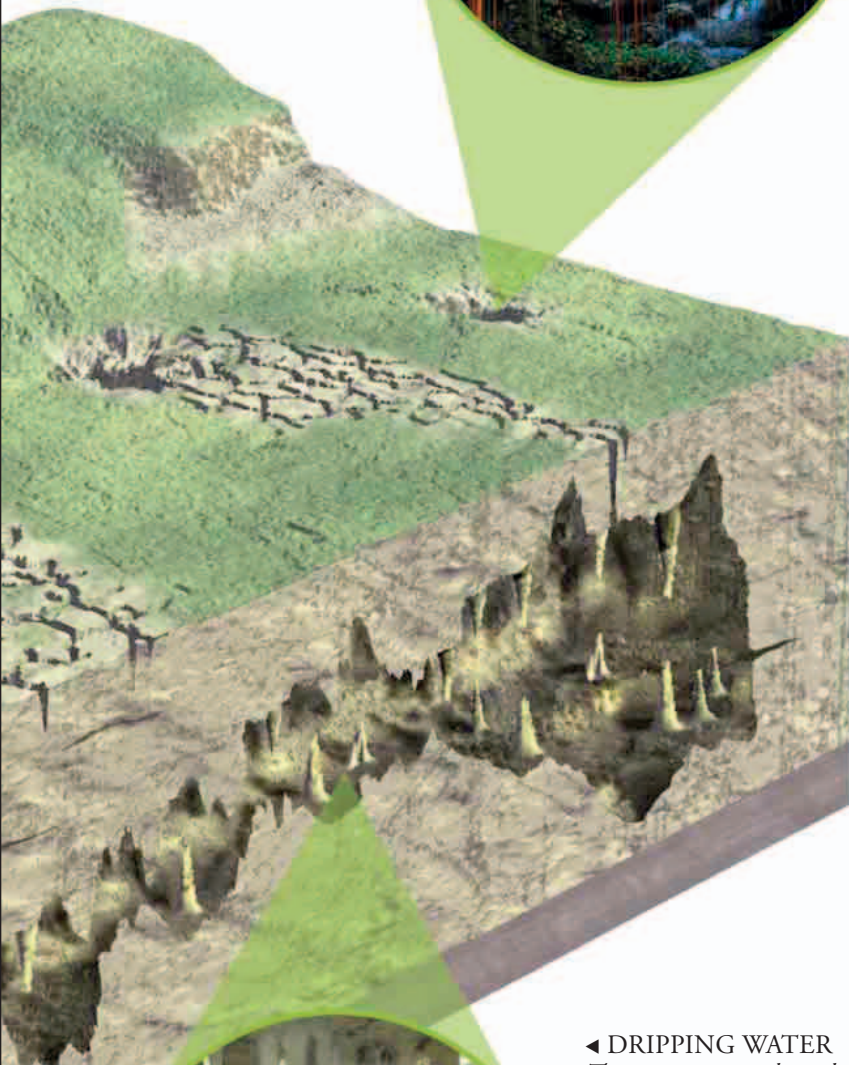


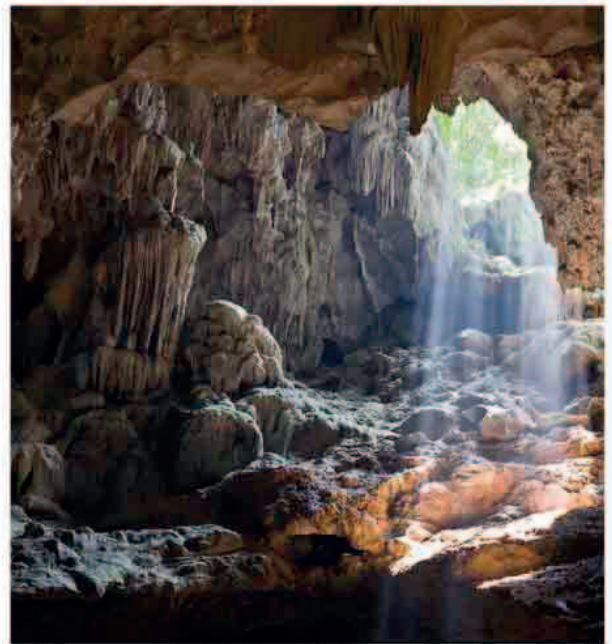
### ► INTO THE VOID

Rainwater often just sinks into the ground, but if it flows over impermeable rock first, it may form a stream. When this stream flows onto limestone, it soon finds a weak point and enlarges it into a vertical shaft, or sinkhole. All the water cascades into the hole and down into the dark void below.



### ◀ DRIPPING WATER

The water seeping through the rock is full of dissolved lime (calcium bicarbonate). When it drips into a cave, the dissolved lime is exposed to air and turns to solid calcite. Over centuries, the calcite builds up at drip points to form stalactites and other rock sculptures.



### CAVERNS

Water flows through flooded tunnels in the lower parts of the cave network. But if it finds an even lower route, it will abandon the tunnels, which then become dry caves. Sometimes a cave ceiling collapses, enlarging it into a cavern with a broad arching roof. Caverns can be colossal, with ceilings more than 650 ft (200 m) high.

WATER



### MEXICAN CENOTES

On the Yucatán Peninsula in Mexico, rainwater draining into limestone has created a vast network of caves. Many have collapsed and are open to the sky, revealing pools of clear water known as cenotes. These were once a vital source of water for the local Maya people.



### ▲ CAVE DIVERS

Specially equipped divers explore a beautiful cenote in Mexico's Yucatán Peninsula.